

PROMPT: ChatGPT attacks the premise, before any spine exists

Updated 2026-08-29 against premise v6, after Trish's agreed read of v5.

Paste the block below. Attach `four-keys-the-premise-for-readers.pdf` (v6, the current premise). If it wants the machinery behind it, add `episode-1-premise-four-keys-v1.0.pdf` (conditions and rulings) and `five-keys-premortem.pdf` (history).

★ **This is deliberately being run BEFORE a spine.** Two spines this week cost a full day each before the earliest-action sweep found their hole. Attacking a shape costs an hour; attacking a spine costs the day that built it.

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You have audited three premises for this project. **Every finding you have returned has been accepted without contest, and two of them killed or reworked a premise.** You also named the recurring defect better than we had — *accurate nodes and a false graph* — and the earliest-action sweep you wrote is now a permanent pipeline step with a recipient column added after we ran it one column short.

This is a different job. There is no spine yet, and that is the point.

What has changed since you last saw this project

Three readers scored roughly 190 one-line premises independently. All three put the same one first: 10 from one, 8 from another, 8.5 from the third. **That ten is the only ten awarded to anything in the entire exercise.** It has been developed into the premise attached, and no prose exists.

The premise has since moved through six versions, and the reader who gave the ten has read it in full and agreed. Two amendments from that read are folded in: the death now has a named injury, blunt force trauma to the head at the foot of her own stairs, exactly what a fall leaves; and the story is committed to answering what the dead woman hid. **The contents themselves are deliberately undecided.**

Two corrections we have taken and you should know about:

1. ★ **The least-cost test asks whether an antagonist's actions are coherent with what HE wants, not whether they minimise his risk.** Run the narrow way it had been forcing every antagonist toward silence, and then the plot kept inventing reasons they could not simply leave. **Do not fail this premise for having a killer who does something risky, if what he does is coherent with what he wants.** The guardrail is that *he is a psychopath* explains what he wants and never how he does it.
2. **Attacking early.** You get one hour of shape rather than a day of structure.

Your job

Findings only. Do not write an alternative premise. Do not write prose. Do not re-derive the pre-mortem. If you think it should die, say so in one paragraph and stop.

Be harder than you want to be. Your findings have been accepted every time, which gives you every social reason to be agreeable now. This premise has more reader enthusiasm behind it than anything else this project has produced, which is exactly why an error in it is expensive.

Attack in this order. It is our own ranking of where it is weakest.

1. **★★ The disappearance as alibi. This is the load-bearing claim and I think it is the weakest joint.** The premise says he vanishes, then a fourth friend is murdered, and that going first makes him look like a victim rather than a suspect. **But a man who disappears days before his friend is murdered is the first person any competent officer would think about.** A vanished person is a classic suspect, not a classic victim. **So: does the alibi work at all?** If it does not, does the premise survive by having police privately suspect him while the public account and the two survivors do not? Or does it need something that positively indicates he was taken, which he would then have had to stage? **We would rather be told this fails now than after a spine.**
2. **Why does she make the arrangement instead of going to the police?** She is frightened enough to hide proof and set up delivery of keys after her death. **Name the reason that is not cowardice or stupidity.** Our candidate: what she had was not yet proof, and using it meant accusing somebody she loved.
3. **The empty cupboard.** Four keys go out at the same time. **Why did only one of them go straight there?** And what does the killer do with proof that names him — destroy it, or keep it because it names something else as well?
4. **The second murder is committed by a man who is supposed to be dead.** He has to stay hidden and kill somebody, in a city where his face has just been in the news as a missing person. **Cost that.**
5. **Can a podcast actually establish that a man is alive?** That is the third act. The proof is meant to be a person in his new life who knows him under another name. **Find the reason a serialised public investigation reaches her and the police did not,** or tell us there isn't one.
6. **The two survivors suspecting each other.** It requires them not to suspect the missing man. **Is that psychologically credible, or is it the plot needing them to be wrong?**

Rules for your findings

- **A finding names what breaks,** with a person and a moment. *"This is thin"* is a note.
- **Rank them with your own confidence.**
- On your **top three only:** one line on *what would have to be true for this finding to be wrong.*
- **Where it depends on an unsettled Havenbay process, ask for the ruling rather than inventing one.** We expect at least two: what allows an unwitnessed fatal fall, blunt force trauma at the foot of her own stairs, to be recorded as an accident with nobody investigating, and what reopens it; and how a person is declared or presumed dead and what that presumption survives.
- **★ Separate "this is wrong" from "this is not yet decided."** There is no spine, so almost nothing is decided. Only report the second kind where the decision looks impossible rather than merely unmade.

Two constraints on output

No menus. If you have a better version of something, state the one you would ship. **Four pages.**

One more job: constraints on what she hid

The premise commits to answering what was in the cupboard, and it is deliberately not yet decided. **Do not pick it.** Name the constraints anything in that cupboard must satisfy for the premise to hold. Ours so far: it fell short of proof, or she would have used it · using it meant accusing somebody she loved · it was worth a murder to the man it named, and worth emptying before four keys arrived in the post · he emptied it rather than ignored it, so possessing it must have been more dangerous to him than the empty cupboard that told all four someone had been there. **Add any constraint we have missed, and flag any pair of them that cannot be satisfied by the same object.**

One question outside the audit

The reader who gave this a ten has rejected roughly a hundred and eighty other ideas from us this week, most of them for being clever rather than affecting.

Ignoring whether it can be built: what is this premise actually about? Not the mechanism. **What does a listener come away carrying?** We think it is that two people were spared because they were not good enough to work it out, and the one who was good enough died for it, and neither survivor will ever say that out loud. **Tell us if that is really what is in there, or if we are reading a better story into a clever one.** One paragraph, separate from the findings.

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